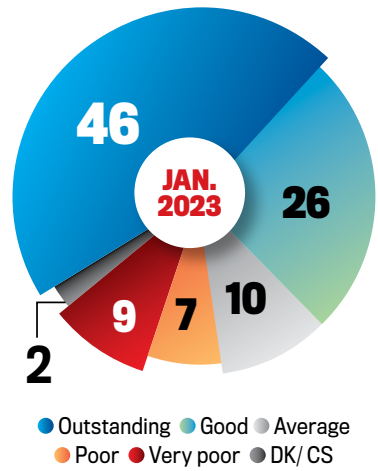
his entire team. Thus the satisfaction levels with the NDA government have gone up from 58.7 per cent in January 2022 to 67.1 per cent, a creditable 9 percentage-point increase. This despite the 'polycrisis' that the government has had to confront, especially on the economic front.

In contrast, Dr Manmohan Singh's approval ratings in his ninth year as prime minister had plummeted, with only 29 per cent of those surveyed in the January 2013 MOTN poll rating his performance as good to outstanding. A year and a half before the 2014 general election, UPA-II was down to 152-162 seats from the 262 it had actually won in the 2009 election. Both these findings were portents of the political doom that awaited Manmohan Singh and the Congress the next year. UPA-II was blown away by the storm unleashed by the Narendra Modi-led Bharatiya Janata Party, which won a simple majority on its own. It sounded the death knell for the Congress, which was reduced to 44 seats in the 543-member House.

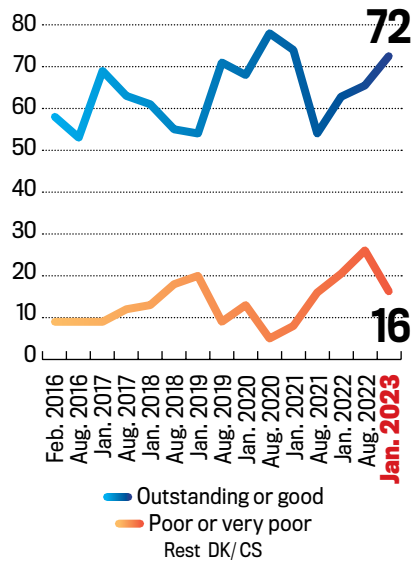
Unlike for UPA-II in 2013, no such ill tidings are visible for NDA-II in the current MOTN survey. If anything, the Modi-led alliance is in pole position to win the 2024 general election. If the parliamentary polls were held now, the survey predicts that the NDA would win 298 seats, nine less than the MOTN prediction six months ago and a 54-seat drop from the actual tally in the 2019 Lok Sabha polls when it returned to power.

While the falling numbers should be a cause for concern for the NDA, importantly for the BJP, its individual tally remains at 284. Though it is a drop of 19 seats from the actual figure of 303 it won in 2019, it still gives the BJP a clear majority of 12 seats more than the 272 needed to form a government on its own. That is a huge psychological advantage as

Q HOW DO YOU RATE THE PERFORMANCE OF NARENDRA MODI AS PRIME MINISTER?



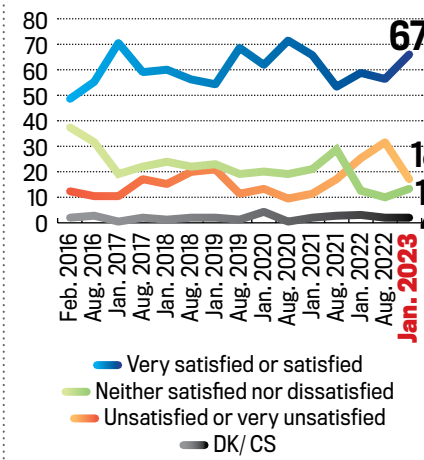
MODI'S PERFORMANCE OVER THE YEARS



53%

MUSLIM RESPONDENTS ARE SATISFIED WITH PM NARENDRA MODI'S PERFORMANCE

Q HOW SATISFIED ARE YOU WITH THE OVERALL PERFORMANCE OF THE NDA GOVERNMENT?



it gears up this year to ensure that it puts as much distance as possible between itself and the Opposition in the final year of its second term.

The BJP's good showing comes despite the respondents' misgivings regarding the NDA government's performance on the economy. Asked what they see as the biggest failures of the NDA-II government, 55 per cent of respondents listed economic issues, including price rise, unemployment, slow economic growth and demonetisation.

A majority of those surveyed also said their economic situation had remained the same or even deteriorated since Modi came to power in 2014. Sixty per cent also said they found it difficult to make ends meet, belying the utopia of "*Achhe Din*" that Modi had promised when he was first voted to power. All this should be potentially devastating for any ruling party's fortunes at the hustings. But not so, it seems, for Modi and his government.

So, what explains the paradox of Modi and the NDA-II's increasing